

Alpha ex Machina Quick Reference

Your turn

1. **Margin, then refresh:** uncommitted funding sources pay Margin; then committed cards become available.
2. **Settle:** pay interest; collect office income and Yield (choose Surplus or a card for Patent Portfolio); from round 4 pay the **dividend** (1, then 1 more every 2 rounds); pay carrying costs or discard the card (the total rounds down).
3. **Refill** to your hand size (5; cards change it; min 2; CEO counts).
4. **Operate:** add 1 funding source (no immediate Margin); 1 staffing move (hire, play CEO, or open an office); buy tools; play investments, treaties, covers; run Surprise Inspections; use abilities; discard any cards.
5. **Close:** margin call (keep 1 Margin Credit per 10 Surplus); no hand limit. Then each other company, in turn order, may run 1 Surprise Inspection.

Stress testing round after the last turn: the pile's top card hits every company; no runner. Empty pile: shuffle the used ones. **Setup:** CEO plus 5 cards; redraw the 5 once. Everyone shows the 5, CEO, and HQ, then secretly picks 5 of 10 Stress Tests for one shuffled pile. Fixed turn order.

Money

- **Leverage:** commit a funding source for 1; committed cards are available again next turn (on paper, slide them forward); unspent Leverage is lost.
- **Surplus:** your capital. 0 or less $\Rightarrow$ insolvent.
- **Alternate payment:** only when a card says so. Pay the full adjusted Leverage cost in Surplus, one for one; keep 1. Normal timing still applies. Cameron commits to allow this for one card.
- **Margin:** uncommitted sources pay before refreshing. Insurance base: printed exposures minus 2 (minimum 1); Financials, including Funding Agreement Notes: 0. Add bonuses. Auto-commit: lowest Margin first.
- **Hire:** pay Leverage. **Poach** (only cards that say so): Hire cost + 2 Surplus; not a staffing move; the poached employee gains Non-compete and arrives committed (gardening leave).
- **Price:** pay Leverage to buy a tool. Not a talent move; one of each; never poached or fired. Its exposures count like a funding source's.
- **Liquidate** any time: Sale value as Leverage or Surplus. Meme Stock waits until your next turn, even for forced sales.
- **Fire Sale:** after a sale by a company under 10 Surplus, everyone under 15 sells that investment for half its Sale value, rounded down.
- **Long vol:** when a Volatility Stress Test hits you, each VIX Calls or Long Straddle gains 10% of the table's loss.

Running a Stress Test

1. **Surprise Inspection:** pay its Leverage; choose the target.
2. **Response window:** left of the runner first, runner last; from the pile, the first player first. Responses, committed talent, offices, or tools, liquidation. No responses to responses.
3. **Stop:** cancel a Surprise Inspection. Pay extra Leverage to push through only if the Stop names a price. From the pile, a Stop protects only you. Acts of God can't be stopped.
4. **Resolve,** then check insolvency.

A free Bank Run (Emergency Equity Infusion) is run in full at once, at one opponent, never Escalated; then the Stress Test it interrupted picks up again. Everything Is Securities Fraud: when the Stress Test ends, its target loses what Stress Tests have cost it this round, again.

Financials (banks and funds)

- **Retail Deposits:** Short-Term Rates exposure, except a third of them (rounded down), which have none; a bank run takes half, rounded down, counting Venture Deposits and Evergreen Credit with them.
- **Investor Capital:** Short-Term Equity exposure.
- **Private Credit:** no exposure; carrying cost $1\frac{1}{2}$.
- **Margin Credit:** no exposure; carrying cost 1; margin call at the end of your turn.
- **Loans** (Credit Cards, Mortgage Lending, Prime Brokerage) are investments with a Credit exposure.

Headquarters and offices

HQ starts free on your board, outside the 40 cards, and stays. Pay **Open** in Leverage for a branch; it shares your staffing move. One of each city per company. Offices produce no Leverage, have no carrying cost, and cannot be poached or fired. Close a branch with no refund; never your HQ. **Fully Remote:** HQ only, no other offices. Offices with funding income pay 1 Surplus per 3 matching sources at turn start, rounded down; committed sources count. **Chicago** instead counts your three futures treaties together, including NFT copies. Opening an office does not refresh purchase discounts. Commit prevention is a total across matching clauses.

Drawing and discarding

Stress Tests draw nothing. Discard face up. To draw from an empty deck, shuffle your discard pile into a new deck and keep drawing. Stop only if both piles are empty.

Uncommit: make a different non-funding card you control available again. Executive Assistant and Delegation Dashboard each do this once between the starts of your turns. Readyng or replaying them does not restore a spent use.

Who gets hit

Pile: every company · **Each opponent** (not you) · **Target opponent.** While any living company controls **Tail Dependence**, every Surprise Inspection is Systematic (you too) and cannot Escalate.

Loss math

Clause amount $\times$ (exposures - hedges, min 0). **x2** counts twice. Nat Cat: Any matches every Nat Cat peril. Fixed exposures (Onion Farms) always count in full. Escalation keeps the same damage.

Quota Share, Side Letter, Catastrophe XoL, and Dynamic Hedging cost 1 Surplus a turn; other halving and loss-cap treaties have no carrying cost.

Protection order: failed programs ("Destroyed if") $\rightarrow$ covers, ignores, flips $\rightarrow$ halving $\rightarrow$ flat reductions $\rightarrow$ swap payments $\rightarrow$ responses, talent, offices, and tools $\rightarrow$ XoL cap $\rightarrow$ recoveries.

Insolvency

Auto-sell liquid investments. Still at 0 or less: out. Too Big to Fail makes a failure cost everyone else 5 Surplus. If its fallout makes every remaining company fail after automatic sales, its controller wins. Qualifying controllers in the same final wave share the win.

Decks and table size

Deck: 40 cards plus 10 Stress Tests. 3 copies of a card; 1 of a **Signature** card; any number of a **Staple** card. **AI:** AI Bubble Bursts destroys it.

Players	2	3	4
Starting Surplus	14	22	30

No round limit. Last solvent company wins, or reach twice starting Surplus (28/44/60). Finish the action or Stress Test, including turn-start settlement and follow-ups, first. Simultaneous qualifiers share the win.

Keywords

Look ahead Scenario Planner or Early Warning System: commit to see the pile's top card. **Act of God** can't be stopped. **Developing Event** stage 1, then a stage a round instead of a new pile card. **Systematic** hits you too. **Escalate** pay 2 more Leverage to hit every opponent instead of one; same damage. **Illiquid** can't be sold. **Non-compete** can't be poached. **CEO** named Signature Talent; fixed for pre-made decks. Starts in hand. Pay Hire in Leverage and a staffing move to play. Never poached. Firing returns it to hand; pay again to replay. Normal discards apply. **Dark** Stress Tests may charge separately per Dark card on your board and in your discard pile. Hand and deck do not count. The Paper Shredder removes discard evidence.